Archlinux System Tweaks

- **Objective:** recover linux from unexpected shutdown
- **Stumble upon:** r/archlinux

Update grub parameters

- **Goal(s):** update grub boot parameters to splash `screen` and hide grub `menu`
  - Add `splash` parameter to kernel parameter: `GRUB_CMDLINE_LINUX_DEFAULT="... splash"`
  - Add `hidden` parameter to `GRUB_TIMEOUT_STYLE`: `GRUB_TIMEOUT_STYLE=hidden`

Enable zswap

- **Goal(s):** enable system zswap on boot
  - Add `zswap.enable=1` to kernel parameter: `GRUB_CMDLINE_LINUX="... zswap.enabled=1"`

Config `pacman`

- **Goal(s):** config `pacman` to:
  - Output colors: `Colors`
  - have a funny animation `IloveCandy`

Reverse Packages Upgrade

- To reverse an `official` package use Archlinux Archive @Archwiki
- To reverse an AUR package check out AUR Downgrade @AUR

Fix screen tearing

- **Objective:** *Rock archlinux without a compositor*
  - **References:** Intel TearFree @Orgmode

Screen Time Event

- **OBJECTIVE:** Do not turn off screen when a media is playing `archlinux`

- **[NOTE]** taken on [2025-08-14 16:24]:
  - Suspending screen saving when a media is playing via: Disable DPMS if ALSA is currently playing sound @Arch-forum
  - Adopt a `cron-job` for `dpms`:
    - Script to detect playing media and set timer for display off timer

```bash
#!/bin/bash
# shellcheck disable=SC2155
set -euo pipefail

declare -ir _timeout=600
declare -ir _current="$(xset -display :0.0 q | awk '/Standby:/ {
↪  print $2 }')"

_enable() {
if [[ "${_current}" == "0" ]]
then
xset -display :0.0 dpms ${_timeout} ${_timeout} ${_timeout}
fi
}

_disable() {
if [[ "${_current}" != "0" ]]
then
xset -display :0.0 dpms 0 0 0
fi
}

if grep -q "RUNNING" /proc/asound/card*/pcm*/sub*/status
then
_disable
else
_enable
```

    - Systemd `timer` and `service`

```
[Unit]
Description=Timer to check for display screen off
```

```
[Timer]
OnBootSec=5
OnUnitActiveSec=1min
Unit=dpms.service

[Install]
WantedBy=timers.target
[Unit]
Description=A dmps checker for media files

[Service]
Type=oneshot
ExecStart=/usr/local/bin/dpms-media
```

- **Reference:** Do Not Turn Display Off When a Media is Playing @Arch-forum

Disable fallback initramfs generation

Generation of fall `initramfs` can lead to full `boot` drive and thus unable to upgrade system or packages. To disable to generation of fallback image [fn:disable-fallback-img]:

- Change `PRESETS('default' 'fallback')` line to `PRESETS=('default')` in the repective *.preset* files in `/etc/mkinitcpio.d/`
- Remove the fallback initramfs images in `/boot/`
- Update your boot loader configuration: `mkinicpio -P`

> [!CAUTION] Disabling all fallback initramfs generation will leads to booting problems when the default image fails. Make sure you have to bootable installation medium for rescue purposes

Reference:* USB flash installation medium

User Service Proxy

Sometimes we want a `user-service` to run along with `system-services` on `systemd` init system. There are a few ways to tackle this problem.

- Elevating service privileges

- Create a proxy service that runs when a system-service started and signal the `user-service` to run on demand

  ```
  [Unit]
  Description=Start user ac.target
  After=powerup.service

  [Service]
  Type=oneshot
  ExecStart=/sbin/systemctl --user --machine=%i@ start ac.target

  [Install]
  WantedBy=ac.target
  ```

  - To start the proxy-service run:

    ```
    systemctl enable --now ac@whammou.service
    ```

Mounting USB Storage

- Auto-mounting with `udisks` - this is the easiest and most frequent used method
  - **Installation:** Install the `udisks2` or `udisks2-btrfs` module via `pacman`
  - **Usage:** To use mount a USB drive first define the block device:
    * To lists all system mount points, run: `$ lsblk`
    * To mount a drive, run: `$ udisksctl mount -b /dev/sdb1`
    * or to unmount: `$ udisksctl unmount -b /dev/sdb2`
- Mounting using `yazi`:
  - Install plugin `mount.yazi` via `$ ya pkg add yazi-rs/plugins:mount`
  - Create custom keybinds:

    ```
    [[mgr.prepend_keymap]]
    on  = "M"
    run = "plugin mount"
    ```

  - Launch the *mount-manager* inside `yazi` with `M`

System Swap and Swappiness

What are swap and swappiness and how to increase system performance by adjusting swappiness value

> `Linux` divides its physical RAM into chunks of memory called pages. `swapping` is a the process whereby a page of memory is copied to the preconfigured space on the hard disk *(a swap page)*, to free up that page of memory

> [!NOTE] The amount of `physical memory` and `swap space` is the amount of virtual memory available

- **goto:** Archlinux System Tweaks @Org

Swap Space & Swap Partition & Swap File

A `swap space` can take the form of a disk partition or a file. `Swap space` can be used for 2 purposes:

- To extend the `virtual memory` beyond the installed `physical memory`
- And also add Suspend-to-disk support @Org
  - To check swap status, use:
    `swapon --show`
  - To show whole `virtual memory` as swap usage:
    `free -h`

1. Swap Partition

   A `swap partition` is a dedicated disk partition used for `swap space`. To enable the device for paging

   `swapon /dev/sdxy`

   A brief comparison between `swap partition` and `swap file`: Swap partition vs Swap file @Opencode-session

2. Swap File

   As an alternative to create an entire `partition`

   - A `swap-file` offers the ability to vary its size *on-the-fly*
   - And is more easily removed altogether
   - This is desirable if the disk space is at premium (e.g. SSD)

   a) Swap File Creation

> [!WARNING] There are some limitations of the implementation in ‘btrfs‘ and linux swap subsystem
>
> - Swap files on file systems spanning multiple devices are not supported
> - Data profile must be single
> - ‘snapshot‘ cannot be create for sub-volumes containing active ‘swap-file‘
> - ‘swap-files‘ must be pre-allocated
> - **copy-on-write** must be disabled individually for ‘swap-files‘ **(i.e., swap files must have to NOCOW attribute)**

To properly create a `swap-file` on `btrfs`

- First, create *sub-volume* as *snap-shots* cannot be created for that sub-volume afterwards:

  ```
  btrfs subvolume create /swap
  ```

- Create a 4GB swap-file `swap-file` in `/swap/`:

  ```
  btrfs filesystem mkswapfile --size 4g --uuid clear
  ↪  /swap/swapfile
  ```

- Activate the swap-file:

  ```
  swapon /swap/swapfile
  ```

- Finally, edit the `fstab` configuration to ad an entry for the swap-file:

  ```
  /swap/swapfile none swap defailts 0 0
  ```

b) Swap File Removal

To remove a swap-file, it must be turned off first and then can be removed:

```
swapoff /swap/swapfile
rm -f /swap/swapfile
```

And remove the relevant entry from `/etc/fstab`

System Swappiness

> When ‘memory‘ reaches a certain threshold, the kernel starts looking at active memory and seeing what it can free up
>
> - File data can be written out to the file system
> - unloaded and re-loaded later

> - Other data must be written to swap before it can be unloaded

The `swappiness` parameter represents the kernels preference for writing to swap instead of files.

- It can have a value between *0* and *200*
- The default value is *60*
  - A *low* value causes the `kernel` to prefer freeing up open files
  - a *high* value causes the `kernel` to try to use swap space

To check the current `swappiness` value:

```
sysctl vm.swappiness
```

To temporarily set the `swappiness` value:

```
sysctl -w vm.swappiness=20
```

To set the `swappiness` value permanently, create a `sysctl.d(5)` configuration file:

```
#/etc/sysctl.d/99-swappiness.conf

vm.swappiness = 20
```

To have the `boot-loader` set the swappiness when loading the `kernel`

- Add a `kernel-parameter` e.g. `sysctl.vm.swappiness=20`